



Côte d'Ivoire's volatile political situation has repeatedly raised fears of a return to all-out conflict, leaving the country's estimated 800,000 IDPs facing an increasingly precarious future. While South Africa's mediation efforts failed to narrow the gap between the government of President Laurent Gbagbo and the rebel *Forces Nouvelles*, and the transition period after the collapsed October 2005 elections giving particular cause for concern, many UN agencies and NGOs in the country made contingency plans for the "worst case scenario" entailing massive displacement and refugee flows into neighbouring countries. Meanwhile existing IDPs have been largely neglected and in an extremely vulnerable situation, the vast majority of them effectively hidden in desperately overburdened host communities. At the heart of the conflict, long-standing tensions between indigenous communities and settlers from neighbouring countries including Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger (as well as Ivorians from northern ethnic groups) – essentially over land – remain particularly acute in the volatile western region. Here, inter-community attacks and low level displacement have been continuing unabated. These tensions, exploited and exaggerated into a form of xenophobic hatred by politicians at the highest level, hold the key both to the country's destruction and, if properly addressed, its possible reconstruction.

A protection crisis

Throughout the crisis in Côte d'Ivoire, IDPs have been particularly vulnerable to serious and widespread human rights abuses committed by both government and rebel militia and youth groups, mostly with impunity. There have been continuing reports of attacks against civilians in general by all parties to the conflict – including killings, disappearances, torture and destruction. Extortion and racketeering are rampant throughout the country. Sexual and gender-based violence, particularly against displaced women and girls, is of major concern. Repeated displacement and lack of access to education has resulted in rising levels of prostitution and domestic slavery. Sexual exploitation of displaced girls by the "impartial forces" (covering both UNOCI and French peacekeepers) has also been reported by humanitarian agencies in Côte d'Ivoire. More than one reliable source has given detailed information about the "procurement" of displaced girls for sex by peacekeeping troops, including inside IDP centres.

Due to the ongoing inflammation of ethnic and religious tensions, displaced Ivorians have been particularly vulnerable to abuse at the hands of armed fighters as well as local communities, particularly in the cocoa-rich western region. There, UNOCI's Human Rights Division reports constant inter-community clashes and displacements, particularly where IDPs no longer have access to their plantations. Militant youth groups continue to be particularly active between Guiglo and Bolequin, towards the Liberian border, with the villages of Kaade and Guinkin as worrying trouble spots.

Important protection issues have also been raised by the premature return of IDPs to their areas of residence in the western region. Although landowners have in some cases encouraged the return of IDPs to prepare for the start of the agricultural season, local populations have reportedly been alarmed and frightened by the return of "non-native" settlers. Likewise, some IDPs are



IDPs taking refuge at the Duékoué Catholic Mission, Côte d'Ivoire, 2005
(Claudia McGoldrick/IDMC)



Displaced man in Guiglo IDP camp, Côte d'Ivoire, 2005
(Claudia McGoldrick/ IDMC)

unwilling to return before disarmament takes place. In some cases where return has been encouraged, for example by the UN's pilot return project in the village of Fengolo, returnees have found their plantations occupied, resulting in dangerous inter-community tensions and urgent calls for local peace and reconciliation work

As a result, some communities are effectively stuck in a situation of internal displacement: for example, many ethnic Baoulé from the northern town of Bouaké displaced in Yamoussoukro are unwilling or unable to return home because of security fears. Without access to employment, IDPs have thus become particularly vulnerable to recruitment by both government and rebel forces. In the rebel *Forces nouvelles* areas, for example around the north western town of Man, child soldiers (including girls) are widely in evidence particularly at checkpoints.

In Abidjan, the government policy of destroying shantytowns housing largely West African immigrants who were perceived to support the rebellion – at its height in late 2002 – has left an estimated 120,000 IDPs in the city, many of them in an extremely precarious state. With ethnic tensions never far from the surface, immigrants, northern Ivorians and Muslims – including the many internally displaced – remain particularly vulnerable to attacks by pro-government militia that are active in many areas of the city.

In an unprecedented move, the UN Security Council imposed sanctions in February 2006 against three Ivorian political figures it considered guilty of a range of serious human rights abuses and who constituted “a threat to the peace and reconciliation process in Cote d'Ivoire”. These included two leaders of the Young Patriots, a pro-government militia, as well as a rebel leader. The decision to impose the travel ban and freeze the assets of the three individuals finally came after several days of orchestrated violence against UN peacekeepers and humanitarian offices in January – incited largely by pro-government militia – that forced the retreat of hundreds of troops and civilian staff, and caused millions of dollars worth of damage.

Hidden humanitarian needs

The humanitarian situation of the vast majority of Ivorian IDPs – effectively hidden within overburdened and also vulnerable host communities – is evidently very poor.

There is only one purpose-built IDP camp in Côte d'Ivoire, in the western town of Guiglo, housing some 6,800 IDPs in two sites. Although intended as a temporary transit centre, many IDPs – predominantly Burkinabé immigrants from around the towns of Bolequin and Toulepleu near the Liberian border – have been living in the camp since the beginning of the crisis in 2002. Temporary IDP centres have also been established in a few other locations, for example in Catholic Mission buildings in the western town of Duékoué and in the capital Yamoussoukro.

The humanitarian situation of IDPs and other vulnerable groups is particularly fragile in the north and west of the country where basic social services are poor if not non-existent. The main issues for concern include the lack of potable water, food insecurity, lack of access to health services and lack of access to education. Malnutrition rates remain high, particularly among children under five. Waterborne diseases are rife, curable diseases have been on the increase, while the HIV/AIDS prevalence rate has reached at least seven per cent – the highest in West Africa – which may increase further in the event of renewed population displacements. At the same time access to health care is extremely poor – for IDPs and other vulnerable groups alike – with some 600,000 people in the western region lacking access, according to international NGOs.

In rebel-held areas, many schools have not been functioning since the outbreak of the crisis in 2002, not least because large numbers of teachers (and other civil servants) remain displaced in major towns in the south. In the north-western town of Man – which hosts an unknown number of IDPs (although substantially less than southern towns) – the non-functioning of schools has been an overriding concern of both residents and humanitarian agencies. The UN estimates that in Côte d'Ivoire more than 700,000 children, mostly girls, have been denied access to primary education since 2002 due to a lack of teachers and worsening living conditions. However, in February 2006 the interim government announced a new plan to restore schooling in the northern half of the country that could pave the way for more than 90,000 students to sit key exams within a matter of months or even weeks.

In the economic capital Abidjan, an estimated 120,000 vulnerable IDPs are living an extremely precarious existence, many of them in shanty towns housing West African immigrants as well as Ivorians of predominantly northern ethnic groups. With the destruction of many shanty towns in Abidjan by government forces and their allied militia in 2002-2003, the arrival of new IDPs added to the burden of residents in making ends meet. Yet with the exception of some immediate albeit ad hoc emergency assistance by various agencies in the aftermath of shanty town destruction, the longer term humanitarian needs of the urban displaced in these areas have been completely overlooked.

Clearly, the lack of information on the numbers, locations and needs of the displaced has been a fundamental obstacle to an effective response. Ongoing low-level displacement together with small-scale spontaneous return has made existing estimates less and less precise. A UNFPA-funded IDP survey, carried out in five key areas in the government zone, was completed in November 2005, with final results expected to be published in early 2006. It is hoped this will provide a clearer picture of IDPs' numbers, locations and needs.

Boribana shanty town in
Abidjan, Côte d'Ivoire, 2005
(Claudia McGoldrick/IDMC)



Weak response

The state response to the situation of internal displacement in Côte d'Ivoire has been wholly inadequate, not least since at both the policy and operational levels there is little knowledge or experience in tackling humanitarian crises in general. There is no central government coordination mechanism for humanitarian response and no state body with overall responsibility for IDPs. While there is a "Ministry of War Victims" (*Ministère des Victimes, des Déplacés et Exilés de Guerre*) this has been preoccupied with seeking compensation for all victims of the conflict, and has had no real relevance to IDP response.

This situation has been compounded by the continuing absence of local administration and social service workers from many parts of the country, particularly the rebel-held north as well as insecure areas of government-held territory in the west. Although some efforts have been made to re-establish state administration, principally through the *Comité Nationale de la Redéploiement de l'Administration* (CNPRA), the lack of services combined with a deteriorating humanitarian situation remains of major concern. Humanitarian organisations have therefore been working directly with various government institutions aiming to complement their work, but in many cases effectively substituting for them.

At the local level, crisis committees (*comités de crises*) are responsible for registering IDPs and for coordinating and managing humanitarian aid mobilised at the national level – but this has been inconsistent and generally poorly managed, according to international agencies in the country. And in areas under the control of the rebel *Forces Nouvelles* the capacity to deal with the humanitarian needs of vulnerable populations has been even more limited, and access to humanitarian agencies patchy at best.

At the international level, the UN response to the humanitarian crisis in Côte d'Ivoire is headed by the Humanitarian Coordinator, who is also the Deputy Special Representative of the UN Secretary-General, and is supported by UN OCHA. The UN and humanitarian agencies have faced various constraints in responding to the needs of IDPs in Côte d'Ivoire – the lack of government counterparts, lack of IDP data, restricted access and funding shortages among them. Coordination issues have also been problematic, not least the tensions between the UN Mission (UNOCI) and NGOs, with many of the latter complaining about the constraints of working alongside a mission that integrates its peacekeeping and humanitarian components. These tensions came to a head following the resumption of hostilities in Côte d'Ivoire in November 2004, when the response of French troops was widely viewed as highly partial, and by association, that of UNOCI as well. With UN peacekeepers perceived to be taking sides in the conflict, and due to the nature of the integrated mission, some NGOs argued it was very difficult to resume activities in the conflicted-affected areas and still be seen as impartial and independent humanitarian agencies.

Yet the 2005 UN OCHA initiative of bringing together international humanitarian actors in a Protection and IDP Network with the aim of collecting and acting on protection-related information (with internal displacement just one component of broader protection concerns) may – potentially – make the international response more effective.

Key recommendations to the government:

- Establish a clear IDP focal point at the national level to liaise and coordinate with the international community on issues relating to IDP protection and assistance
- Develop a National IDP Policy, including clear return and resettlement strategies that are in line with the UN Guiding Principles
- Support peace and reconciliation efforts particularly in areas of IDP return
- Allow IDPs to move freely and to return to home areas, particularly in the western region, without fear of harassment or reprisal by security forces or civil militia